General Norstad, when they dined on 22 October 1962. Concern to avoid unnecessary military provocation and to promote summitry helped frame his approach to the Cuban crisis. So, too, did loyalty to Washington.

Kennedy's reading of Tuchman's book reinforced his concern that events might slip from his control, as well as his concerns about America's military leaders. Robert Kennedy recounts, 'this experience [of the crisis] pointed out for us all the importance of civilian direction and control and the importance of raising probing questions to military recommendations.'[77] In his authoritative study of US command and control, Joseph Bouchard observes, 'A striking feature of President Kennedy's management of the crisis is his ordering implementation of specific actions contained in the Cuban contingency plans *without* authorizing execution of the overall plans … the President refused to be bound by the timetables and courses of action in the two plans.'[78] Here, Kennedy's attitude to military plans echoes Tuchman's criticisms of General von Moltke's disastrous adherence to German mobilisation plans in August 1914.[79] Of potentially much greater significance, as McNamara argued, was that the President would not have ordered implementation of the SIOP when there were more limited and discriminate options for nuclear retaliation.

That Kennedy recognised the need for close political control of military forces and was conscious of the risks of losing control are without doubt. The operation of the naval blockade is invariably depicted as the exemplar of the political control of the military. Yet, closer scrutiny of what is now known yields a more complex and nuanced picture. It suggests that there were failings in 'civilian direction and control,' and deficiencies in 'raising probing questions to military recommendations.' Furthermore, the received wisdom about the management of the blockade is based on a misleading representation of one of the most iconic moments of the crisis, when ExComm gathered on 24 October to learn whether Soviet ships were running the blockade. It was misleading because ExComm itself was misled about what was happening at sea that morning. The historical record provides an accurate account of an entirely inaccurate representation of events.